

Community-Driven AI: A Roadmap for India's Last Mile

Dates: 7–8 February 2026

Venue: Seminar Hall, IIT Delhi, New Delhi

Organizers:

Yardi School of Artificial Intelligence, IIT Delhi

Bhagwan Birsa Munda Cell (BBMC), IIT Delhi



1. Programme Overview

Indian Institute of Technology Delhi (IIT Delhi) will convene a two-day, outcome-oriented pre-summit titled “Community-Driven AI: A Roadmap for India’s Last Mile” on 7–8 February 2026 at IIT Delhi, New Delhi. The convening focuses on setting the tone for designing participatory and community-responsive AI ecosystems by centering the lived realities of India’s last-mile communities. These include tribal communities, linguistic minorities, informal-sector workers, persons with disabilities, ageing populations, remote and low-connectivity populations, and communities with limited access to digital infrastructure and public services.

The event brings together AI researchers, policymakers, civil society leaders, technologists, and community representatives to co-create ethical, participatory, and accountable AI frameworks that are socially grounded, culturally sensitive, and operationally viable.

Through a carefully curated mix of keynote addresses, panel discussions, thematic roundtables, and roadmap-drafting sessions, the workshop aims to develop India’s first Community-Driven AI Roadmap. The deliberations and outcomes will directly inform a White Paper and policy recommendations to guide responsive AI development and deployment in governance, public service delivery, and community-facing digital systems.

2. Context and Rationale

Advances in artificial intelligence (AI) offer transformative potential for public service delivery, especially at the last mile. Yet, many current AI deployments fail to reflect the lived realities of underserved communities, resulting in gaps in access, effectiveness, and accountability. In India, where service delivery is shaped by diverse languages, connectivity limitations, and varying institutional capacities, there is an urgent need for AI systems that are both responsive to local contexts and responsible in design.

This program seeks to bridge that gap by developing a future-oriented, community-driven AI roadmap that is actionable across stakeholders and relevant for global contexts. It emphasises embedding community purpose, contextual intelligence, and local knowledge throughout the full AI lifecycle—from design and data practices to governance. By explicitly accounting for last-mile realities, such as language access, connectivity constraints, and institutional bandwidth, the program ensures that AI interventions are equitable, accountable, and operationally effective.

Beyond technology-centric solutions, the roadmap prioritises participatory approaches, capturing insights from parallel communities and practitioners to shape design principles, safeguard expectations, and minimum requirements such as auditability, source-grounding, and grievance mechanisms. The program thus aligns AI deployment with policy priorities, community expectations, and welfare outcomes, creating systems that are not only technically robust but also socially grounded and ethically accountable.

Vision

- To develop a future-oriented roadmap for community-driven AI systems that respond to last-mile realities in India with relevance for global contexts.
- To embed community purpose, contextual intelligence, and knowledge into the full lifecycle of AI design, data practices, and governance

3. Conceptual Distinctiveness

While many AI forums prioritise technological innovation, product demonstrations, or aspirational narratives about AI's future, this programme distinguishes itself through four operationally grounded differentiators:

- **Community-Driven by Design:** The programme centers on last-mile realities, emphasising language access, lived constraints, service journeys, and the protection of rights, rather than prioritising model capabilities as the primary design driver.
- **Governance-Aligned:** AI is positioned as a component of public service delivery infrastructure, subject to minimum thresholds of transparency, safety, accountability, and recourse, rather than assessed solely on technical performance metrics.
- **Outcome-Oriented:** Sessions are structured to generate shared agreements and actionable recommendations, with methods that translate discussions into concrete needs, guidance, and practical advice.

- **Collaborative, Implementation-Focused:** The programme convenes policymakers, frontline implementers, civil society actors, and technical experts to co-create outputs that are operationally feasible, measurable, and aligned with institutional realities and constraints.

4. Convening Institutions

The Pre-Summit is being organised by the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi (IIT Delhi), anchored by the Yardi School of Artificial Intelligence, in collaboration with the Bhagwan Birsa Munda Cell (BBMC), IIT Delhi, and supported by IIT Delhi's broader academic and institutional ecosystem.

5. Program Objectives

The primary goal of the workshop is to brainstorm, synthesise, and articulate a roadmap for developing community-driven AI in India. Specifically, the workshop seeks to:

1. Frame a community-responsive approach to AI problem identification and prioritisation
2. Explore participatory AI development lifecycles, from community engagement to deployment
3. Identify institutional, regulatory, and design-level enablers required to support this approach
4. Develop a white paper and policy recommendations for government, public agencies, and AI practitioners

Grounded in India's last-mile realities, the roadmap emerging from the workshop is envisioned as scalable across national contexts and relevant for global application, informing not only where AI should be deployed, but how it should be designed, developed, and governed.

6. Programme Structure and Agenda

The two-day agenda is structured to move intentionally from framing to synthesis, ensuring that each session generates actionable insights that feed directly into the roadmap.

Day 1: Opens with the Inauguration and framing sessions that define the mandate, urgency, and scope: what is changing in public AI, where current practices fall short for underserved communities, and what accountable deployment entails. Short invited talks provide evidence from research and practice, emphasising real-world constraints in last-mile service delivery, such as language access, connectivity limitations, institutional capacity, and exclusion risks in welfare-linked interactions.

Panel discussions are designed to be decision-oriented rather than descriptive. The discussions highlight important choices, showing the essential needs like being based on reliable sources, being able to check the process, and having ways to address complaints, compared to parts The "Voices from Parallel Communities" part of the agenda focuses on real-life experiences, recording what communities care about, what they expect to be protected, and the key rules that will shape future technical

The program then shifts into structured breakout working sessions. Using guided templates, the breakout sessions turn ideas into draft parts of a plan, including important use cases, potential problems, basic safety measures, evaluation standards, and limits on

Day 2: Focuses on consolidation and stress testing: breakout outputs are reviewed in plenary, evaluated for feasibility and accountability, refined into agreed-upon actionable suggestions, and organised into a coherent roadmap structure with next-step responsibilities and near-term milestones.

7. Expectations from Participating Stakeholders

Since the program focuses on implementation, it is crucial for ministries, public institutions, and practitioners to actively participate. We request the nomination of officials and program or technical representatives who can contribute to discussions on:

- Priority service journeys and obstacles that impede efficient service provision today
- Observed failure modes in digital delivery and citizen communication
- Feasibility constraints (data availability, connectivity, staffing, grievance workflows)
- Minimum institutional requirements for any AI-enabled citizen-facing system;
- Realistic evaluation, monitoring, and escalation practices within public systems.

These inputs are necessary to ensure that the roadmap is not aspirational but institutionally adoptable and aligned with on-the-ground delivery realities.

8. Participants

The Pre-Summit will convene:

- Representatives from relevant ministries and public institutions
- Academic and technical experts in AI, language technologies, and responsible AI
- Civil society and practitioner organisations working in tribal and last-mile contexts
- Implementation partners and domain experts with on-the-ground experience
- Invited speakers and moderators with governance-facing AI expertise

This composition is intentionally designed to ensure that recommendations are credible across policy, practice, and technology.

10. Expected Outcomes

By the end of the program, the convening will produce a clear, shared Community-Driven AI Roadmap for India's Last Mile, designed to be actionable and relevant for all stakeholders. Key high-level outcomes include:

- An actionable definition of community-driven, welfare-oriented AI for last-mile governance
- A prioritised set of public-interest use contexts and realistic deployment assumptions
- Minimum safeguards and accountability requirements for citizen-facing AI systems
- Evaluation and monitoring expectations are appropriate for high-stakes public services

The emphasis throughout is to improve access and inclusion, reduce exclusion risks, and strengthen trust through transparency, oversight, and recourse.

11. Dates, Venue, and Schedule

The Pre-Summit will be held on 7–8 February 2026 at the Seminar Hall, IIT Delhi, New Delhi.

A tentative schedule is provided below; session titles may be refined as confirmations progress.

Date	Time	Session	Speaker	Notes / Lead
Day 1 — 7 Feb 2026	09:00–09:30	Inauguration	Ms. Ranjana Chopra, Secretary, Ministry of Tribal Affairs	Opening, ceremonial start, welcome remarks
	09:30–10:10	Keynote & Context Setting	Prof. Parag Singla, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Sets framing for last-mile AI and governance
	10:10–10:30	Talk 1	Prof. Ganesh Ramakrishnan, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Bombay	Invited talk
	10:30–10:50	Talk 2	Prof. Rohan Paul, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Invited talk
	10:50–11:20	Break		—
	11:20–11:40	Talk 3	Prof. Sandeep Kumar, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Invited talk
	11:40–12:00	Talk 4	Prof. Arnab Bhattacharya, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur	Invited talk
	12:00–13:10	Panel 1: AI-Centric Perspectives	• Prof. Mausam (Moderator) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi • Prof. Santanu Chaudhary (Panellist) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi • Prof. Arnab Bhattacharya (Panellist) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi • Prof. Srikanta Bethadur (Panellist) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Moderated panel
	13:00–14:15	Lunch		—
	14:20–15:00	Keynote	Mr. Harsh Chohan Shiv Ganga Foundation and Former Chairperson, NCST	Keynote session (virtual)
	15:00–15:20	Talk 5	Prof. Debanandand Mishra, Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Invited talk
	15:20–15:40	Talk 6	Mr. Milind Thatte Head Director TEER and Trustee Vayam Movement	Invited talk
	15:40–16:00	Talk 7	Dr. Sunayana Sitaram	Invited talk

			Researcher Microsoft Researcher	
			Dr. Piyashi Dutta Lead Tribal Research and Knowledge Centre	Invited talk
	16:00–16:20	Talk 8		
	16:20–16:50	Tea		—
			• Dr. Piyashi Dutta (Moderator) Lead Tribal Research and Knowledge Centre • Prof. PVM Rao (Panellist) • Prof. Sahini Vaiekeo (Panellist) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi • Prof. Vivek Kumar (Panellist) Professor CRDT, IIT Delhi • Mr. Milind Thatte (Panellist) Director TEER and Trustee Vayam Movement	Moderated panel
	16:50–18:00	Panel 2: Social-Centric Perspectives		
			• Prof. Raunak Bhattacharya (Moderator), Head of Professor Indian Institute of Technology Delhi • Prof. Jitin Singla (Panellist) Professor Indian Institute of Technology Roorkee • Ms. Sunayana (Panellist) • Mr. Antarsing (Panellist) PG Student MA Tribal Studies, DAVV Indore • Mr. Mukund Aggarwal (Panellist) Young Social Leader	Practitioner/ community voices
	18:00–18:50	Voices from Parallel Communities		
	19:00–20:15	Breakout Session		Working groups; synthesis capture
	20:30–21:30	Dinner		—
Day 2 — 8 Feb 2026	09:00–09:40	Keynote	Prof. PVM Rao Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Keynote session
	09:40–11:00	Talk 9	Prof. Radhika Mamidi, Professor, International Institute of Information Technology, Hyderabad	Invited talk
	10:00–10:20	Talk 10	Prof. Chetan Arora, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology Delhi	Invited talk
	10:20–10:40	Talk 11	Prof. Monojit Chuadhary, Professor, MBUZAI, Abu Dhabi	Invited talk

10:40–11:00	Talk 12	TBD	Invited talk
11:00–11:30	Break		
11:30–12:10	Keynote	Mr. Vibhu Nayar Former Secretary, MOTA	Keynote session
12:10–12:50	Summary of the Breakouts	Prof. Parag, Prof. Vivek, Prof. Sandeep, Prof. Raunak	—
13:00–13:30	Way forward and vote of thanks	Prof. Sandeep Kumar	—